

CONTACT: RELEASING THE NEWS

ROBERTO PINOTTI

Sociologist, FUTURO srl, Florence, Italy

Abstract—The problem of mass behavior after man's future contacts with other intelligences in the universe is not only a challenge for social scientists and political leaders all over the world, but also a cultural time bomb as well. In fact, since the impact of CETI (Contact with Extraterrestrial Intelligence) on human civilization, with its different cultures, might cause a serious socio-anthropological shock, a common and predetermined worldwide strategy is necessary in releasing the news after the contact, in order to keep possible manifestations of fear, panic and hysteria under control. An analysis of past studies in this field and of parallel historical situations as analogs suggests a definite "authority crisis" in the public as a direct consequence of an unexpected release of the news, involving a devastating "chain reaction" process (from both the psychological and sociological viewpoints) of anomie and maybe the collapse of today's society. The only way to prevent all this is to prepare the world's public opinion concerning contact before releasing the news, and to develop a long-term strategy through the combined efforts of scientists, political leaders, intelligence agencies and the mass media, in order to create the cultural conditions in which a confrontation with ETI won't affect mankind in a traumatic way. Definite roles and tasks in this multi-level model are suggested.

1. BACKGROUND

In the late fifties, in his book *Ein Moderner Mythos - Von Dingen, Die Am Himmel Gesehen Werden*[1], psychologist Karl Gustav Jung faced the problem of unidentified flying objects (UFO) suggesting the existence of a modern "flying saucer" myth originated by a timeless objectification of human fears, desires and hopes. Indeed, since conscious and unconscious fantasy, and even mendacity, obviously play an important role in building up a rumor, this explanation could be satisfactory. In other words, according to Jung's theory, man has always been projecting onto the outside world - on Earth and also in the sky - his unconfessed needs, anxieties and illusions with the effect of creating different psychological images. Developing this concept, in the early sixties a French-born American astronomer, Dr. Jacques Vallee, identified with the term Magonia the dimensional interaction of our daily life with unexplained manifestations throughout our history. The common nature behind these different cultural situations was generally acknowledged as "supernatural apparitions": a definite pattern linking what the Romans defined in Latin "prodigia" caused by pagan gods and the Judeo Christian and Islamic tradition considered God's "signs in the sky" with Middle Age fairy tales and latter with the Blessed Virgin Mary's apparitions and finally with today's UFOs and "close encounters[2]." Are these mere myths? Considering them in a non-psychological light, Jung admits that there is another possibility: "that UFOs are real material phenomena of an unknown nature, presumably coming from outer space, which perhaps have

long been visible to mankind but otherwise have no recognizable connection with the Earth or its inhabitants." This paper will not consider the scientific and technical aspects of the UFO enigma. This has been thoroughly studied in the United States by astronomer and USAF "Project Blue Book" consultant Dr. Joseph Allen Hynek after publication of the Colorado University controversial 1969 "Condon Report" and is still being analyzed in the USSR and also in France, through GEPAN a government-sponsored scientific committee of CNES in Toulouse[3]. Apart from the scientific controversy it has generated, the most interesting aspect of the UFO problem is that the popular idea of extraterrestrials visiting Earth provides an excellent "test-tube" for studying the evolution of the possible mass "feedback" to the ETI concept from the psycho-sociological point of view. The public's first reactions date back to the thirties. On the evening of October 30, 1938, many thousands of Americans became panic-stricken by a broadcast purported to describe an invasion of Martians which threatened our whole civilization. These manifestations of panic in widely scattered parts of the United States began shortly after Orson Welles, the actor and producer, had introduced in the New York studios of the Columbia Broadcasting System an adaptation of "The War of the Worlds," written 40 years before by H. G. Wells. People rushed into the streets only partially clothed or struck out aimlessly across open country, fleeing in terror. Cars raced wildly through crowded cities causing serious accidents. Hadley Cantril's study of this most dramatic episode will continue to have special relevance not only for the psychology of panic but also for the fields of

social psychology and collective behavior in general[4]. It also apparently influenced the conclusions of a report submitted to the U.S. Government in 1960. The National Aeronautics and Space Act of July 29th, 1958, called for "long-range studies" of the benefits and problems to be expected from space activities. NASA set up a committee on Long-Range Studies and awarded a study contract to the Brookings Institution. A research team led by Donald N. Michael, the future Director of the Peace Research Institute in Washington, interviewed more than 200 specialists and the resulting report was reviewed by Lloyd V. Berkner, head of the Space Science Board, Margaret Mead, the anthropologist, and other experts. The final document, submitted to NASA only a few months after Project Ozma's historical attempt to intercept signals from Tau Ceti and Epsilon Eridani, suggested that artifacts left by extraterrestrial astronauts "might possibly be discovered through our space activities on the Moon, Mars or Venus"; but even if ETI is discovered in distant solar systems through radio-astronomy, such an event would not necessarily rule out revolutionary effects. In fact, the report said, "Anthropological files contain many examples of societies, sure of their place in the universe, which have disintegrated when they have had to associate with previously unfamiliar societies espousing different ideas and different life styles. Others that survived such an experience usually do so by paying the price of changes in values and attitudes and behavior[5]." Acculturation was not a problem when the Romans confronted the Barbarians; but is Earth the Rome of the Universe?

2. ETI AND CULTURE SHOCK

The modern world is proud of its achievements. In spite of the fact that Copernicus showed that the Earth was not the center of the universe, man has continued to believe that even though he was not geographically in the center of the universe, he is central in essence. This common belief would be shattered by the presence of ETI, even though there would be no evidence that the alien culture might be malevolent, and the masses would be swept into a state of fear. From the psychological point of view, as Karl Gustav Jung said, the "reins would be torn from our hands and we would, as a tearful old medicine man once said to me, find ourselves 'without dreams,' that is, we would find our

intellectual and spiritual aspirations so outmoded as to leave us completely paralyzed[6]." History has many examples of this. In fact, from the cultural point of view, their contact with Europeans castrated African and pre-Columbian societies, destroying most of their original age-old characteristics: from their practical everyday life to their "weltanschauung," their vision of the world and existence. It was a culture shock they had to face, a confrontation with another world: and their technology, their science, their economy, their religion, their philosophy and their ethics disintegrated against the structures of the European civilization. Culture shock is the effect that immersion in a different culture has on the unaware or unprepared visitor, and this term has already begun to creep into the popular vocabulary. In the words of Alvin Toffler[7], "the culture shock phenomenon accounts for much of the bewilderment, frustration, and disorientation that plagues Americans in their dealings with other societies." As Toffler says, culture shock "causes a breakdown in communication, a misreading of reality, an inability to cope. Yet culture shock is relatively mild in comparison with the much more serious malady, future shock. Future shock is the dizzying disorientation brought on by the premature arrival of the future." According to Toffler, "future shock is a time phenomenon, a product of the greatly accelerated rate of change in society. It arises from the superimposition of a new culture on an old one. It is culture shock in one's own society." The malaise, mass neurosis, irrationality, and free-floating violence already apparent in contemporary life are merely a foretaste, of what may lie ahead. In any case, it is evident that our culture is in constant turmoil, with its values incessantly changing and a dominating sense of general disorientation, involving also the weakest, least intelligent, and most irrational - and they are surely the majority - members of society. The result is a cultural time bomb. And it could explode at any time, since this process is affecting not only the Western and Communist Countries, but also the Third World along with the underdeveloped countries on a planetary scale. In this global situation, the news of the existence of ETI could prove to be devastating. In fact, at this particular moment what mankind needs is psycho-sociological balance and rules to follow. The unexpected superimposition of a new and alien component - ETI - on today's critical world scene would cause what usually happens when the familiar psychological cues that help an

individual to function in society are suddenly withdrawn and replaced by new ones that are strange or incomprehensible[8].

On a sociological scale this means a crisis in rules, maybe the sudden lack of rules, or anomie. And anomie is usually associated to the disintegration of a social structure. The first effect of the confirmed presence of ETI would be a definite "authority crisis" all over the world involving not only science, religion and philosophy, but also socio-political structures, in a global attempt to "break with the past" in the face of what everybody will consider the most exciting event in all history. Surely a "revising process" would affect every field of human activity and thought in the light of what would be defined as "the Second Copernican Revolution." Science would be criticized, and most of the conservative scientists ridiculed; new philosophical schools and cults would arise, along with traumatic theological debates in all the churches, religions and sects; the arts would be stimulated and mass media would express all the facets of this general crisis of The Establishment, while socio-economic and political and military structures as we know them today would be doomed. In fact, in today's uneasy world dominated by the general crisis of all ideologies, the presence of ETI would reduce the "Big Two's" global roles to the same geopolitical importance on today's international scene as countries like Andorra, Monaco or the Republic of San Marino. It is evident that the Superpowers' different forms of imperialism, justified by their purported "superiority" all over the world, would be regarded as quite meaningless and outmoded in the presence of alien civilizations in space.

As a result, the first general reaction would be the rise of centrifugal socio-political tendencies everywhere, and the crisis of the present world order. As a consequence of the diffused fear of facing something too different and too difficult to understand, surely people - and peoples - would manifest their ethnocentrism, in an unconscious but logical necessity to save and to exalt their own past's values lest they be lost forever after their confrontation with an alien way of life - a typical behavior in all minorities to keep their cultural identities. This means an evident fragmentation in all multi-cultural, socio-political structures: from the European Community to the Soviet Union and the USA centrifugal socio-political tendencies would manifest, creating serious authority problems for super-national, central and federal governments. Surely not only the "old Europe" logic, but also

the Soviet Marxist-leninist principles and the "American way of Life" spirit as well would be quite unable to control these general fragmentation processes caused everywhere by the sudden loss of importance and credibility of all our established authorities resulting from the unexpected confrontation with extraterrestrial intervention. Some feel that no significant change in the rate of progress could be brought about by this intervention unless the recipient society were to lose its individuality. But it is evident that the more backward of the two societies would never be the same after the "impact of contact". Chances are good that the Earth will be much less advanced than other civilizations in the Universe around us. In this case, K. G. Jung observed in the late fifties that a contact with superior beings might be shattering to our society; to find ourselves no more a match for them intellectually than our pets are for us (as he expressed in modern words Giordano Bruno's concept of extra-terrestrial life), to find suddenly all our aspirations outmoded, might leave our culture not only shaken and fractured, but also completely demoralized. Surely this would be the beginning of the end of human civilization.

The establishment of contact even in the case where the ETI involved were quite beneficial, could not only lead us to many radical changes in our basic concepts regarding an intelligent society, however "logical" these concepts appeared to be prior to contact, but also could greatly affect the future development of our own civilization through a sort of "chain reaction" process of widespread anomie involving and devastating all the aspects of our present world order. This means only that today's Establishment as such would have everything to lose from any form of contact with ETI, being the first victim in this frontal collision of different civilizations. In 1928, astronautics pioneer Konstantin Tsiolkovsky, a small town Russian school teacher who formulated the theoretical foundations of future space travel (like Oberth and Goddard did in Germany and in the USA), wrote that "maybe life on Earth is not yet ready to face the interference of extraterrestrial beings because of the present development of this planet's inhabitants.... Maybe this event would produce harmful consequences for today's mankind....[9]." Tsiolkovsky was neither a psychologist nor sociologist, but he understood in the late twenties what today is more and more evident: the fact that in Tsiolkovsky's words, "until now we have regarded the possibility of participation

of other beings in our life as unconceivable. We can hardly imagine something superior to Earthmen... Such a narrow outlook explains why we don't admit and imagine the possibility of interference of other beings into our life[9]." In other words, ignorance generates fear and fear produces panic, mass hysteria and anarchy.

The American public's feedback to the UFO enigma is enlightening because of the popular idea that "flying saucers" may be visiting spaceships from other worlds. As Captain E. J. Ruppelt, head of the USAF "Project Blue Book" UFO study group admits, "...about Orson Welles' famous 'War of the Worlds' broadcast of October 1938, which caused thousands of people to panic, had we studied this to see if there were any similarities between it and the current UFO reporting? We had... There were similar reports in our UFO files[10]." According to the late Dr. Donald Menzel, the world-famous astronomer, "the public is afraid of 'saucers' and we need only a match to set off a nation-wide panic that could far exceed that of 'The Invasion from Mars' [11]."

This means that, with the exception of limited scientific and cultural elites, a future contact with ETI would produce fear panic, mass hysteria, authority crisis and widespread anomie all over the world, and especially in case Earth's role was passive in this event: if we were discovered by ETI and not their discoverers, we should become the frustrated, demoralized and castrated victims of this frontal collision of different cultures. Since the sixties, possible negative effects of extraterrestrial contacts for mankind were seriously considered only by a few astronomers, like England's Anthony Hewish and Zdenek Kopal and USA's Clyde Tombaugh, who expressed their critical position 17 years ago during the 1970 XXI IAF Congress in Brighton. According to Dr. Kopal, "if there is life in another solar system, it would be dangerous for us to make ourselves conspicuous... An advanced civilization might treat us like ants and put us in test tubes. Look what we have done to lower civilizations - and the way we treat animals[11.5]." Therefore, in Dr. C. Tombaugh's opinion, "it could be a disaster to contact another civilization[12]." Since then other critical opinions have been expressed against enthusiasm in SETI, and the possible risks for human civilization carefully considered. Today social sciences seem to confirm such a diagnosis more and more: mankind is far from being ready for CETI, but ETI might contact us unexpectedly - directly or indirectly - at any moment, and this cultural

"sword of Damocles" could mean in any case general confusion and a crisis of the present world order. What is the best therapy?

3. DEVELOPING A LONG-TERM STRATEGY

Of course it is almost impossible for us to hide in the Universe and we cannot prevent ETI from contacting us at any moment. In other words, the risk of a planetary culture shock generated by a future extraterrestrial contact can never be ruled out. So we must realize we shall have to face it. And the only thing we could and should do is just to try to prevent its negative consequences for mankind as far as possible. As the saying goes, "forewarned is forearmed". In fact, the real danger for human culture is not contact as such, since - under certain circumstances - it might even be stimulating, after all; what we must understand once and for all is the fact that our real problem is just to be ready to live such an historical experience. Surely today's unprepared Earth culture has everything to lose; only a planetary culture fully aware of its role would have a chance to live this confrontation in a positive spirit - no matter what we shall have to face. So it is more and more evident that a growing popular awareness of this problem would be important to reduce and control all over the world the harmful cultural outcomes of such an encounter. It is our only chance to turn the destructive power of this "atom bomb" like disintegration process of our culture into a sort of controlled "nuclear reactor" effect. In other words, a long-term strategy involving SETI in a global education program aimed at developing a general understanding of man's role in the universe is necessary and should be encouraged. This "universal awareness" in future generations is the only key to facing, with all our limits and possibilities, the impact of contact. From this particular viewpoint, and in a merely psychosociological sense, there is much more "universal awareness" in a child's unconscious and a critical belief in science fiction "aliens" than in a respected scientist's updated and responsible knowledge of the possibilities of extraterrestrial life. In fact today's young are tomorrow's public, and their adaptation to the future culture shock caused by contact will be in relation to their positive acceptance of the situation since their childhood. And today more young people become fascinated with space and new frontiers in consciousness. More books and articles appear, changing our culture in the direction of

a higher image of man. Nevertheless SETI is far from being a popular argument, and survey results show the public opinion's general approach to the subject links it to UFOs and related matters. In 1982 David W. Swift, professor of sociology at the University of Hawaii, concluded that belief in ET and UFO is strongest in the most influential stratum of the population in the U.S.; that is, among better informed, higher income people - the very people who would be crucial to public support for SETI. His conclusion was that a more open policy toward UFOs might give NASA an opportunity to educate the public on the difference between UFOs and SETI bringing in more funds, some of which could be devoted to SETI research[13]. Surely, Swift's suggestions could be the first step toward a global educational strategy aimed at developing a "new scientific consciousness" all over the world using the tremendous potential of the general public's interest for popular subjects such as UFOs, whose effect would not be only the proper preparing of masses to the impact of contact, but also an important raising of funds for scientific research. Surely SETI needs to be more and more known and supported in every country and this could be very good strategy in order for achieving three goals at the same time: correct scientific information, proper popular education against the impact of contact, and the raising of more funds for SETI.

Such a "new scientific consciousness" SETI educational strategy would involve not only scientists and scientific organizations in different countries, but also journalists and mass media, along with politics and intellectuals. The stimulating role of scientists and scientific organizations (from IAF to AIAA, to AAAS to BIS, and more) able to develop this action would seriously affect public opinion and this will result in a growing interest of the political world for more government-funded activities, most of which to be devoted to SETI research. In addition to scientists, the media and politicians would be interested in the development of a long-term educational strategy, as would intelligence agencies. In fact many practical aspects of the cultural shock feed-back to be caused by the impact of contact were already faced in the early fifties by the U.S. Government's "Scientific Advisory Panel on UFOs" (14-17 January 1953). The Panel member scientists (H. P. Robertson, Lloyd V. Berkner, L. W. Alvarez, S. A. Goldsmit and astronomer Thornton Page) were in agreement with CIA experts that although evidence of any

direct threat from UFO sighting was wholly lacking, related dangers might well exist, resulting from:

- a. misidentification of actual enemy artifacts by defense personnel;
- b. overloading of emergency reporting channels with "false" information ("noise to signal ratio" analogy - L. V. Berkner);
- c. subjectivity of public to mass hysteria and greater vulnerability to possible enemy psychological warfare.

Astronomer Page noted that more competent screening or filtering of reported sighting at or near the source was required, and that this could best be accomplished by an educational program. The Panel's concept of a broad educational program, integrating efforts of all concerned agencies, was that it should have two major aims: training and "debunking." According to the Panel's report[14] "the training aim would result in proper recognition" of unusual phenomena and "in a marked reduction in reports caused by misidentification and resultant confusion." The "debunking" aim "would result in reduction in public interest in 'flying saucers' which today evokes a strong psychological reaction. This education could be accomplished by mass media such as television, motion pictures, and popular articles.... Such a program should tend to reduce the current gullibility of the public and consequently their susceptibility to clever hostile propaganda." The Panel concluded "that the continued emphasis on the reporting of these phenomena does, in these perilous times, result in a threat to the orderly functioning of the protective organs of the body politic." In order to minimize the concomitant dangers of all this ("hysterical behavior and harmful distrust of duly constituted authority" in the Report's words), the Panel recommended:

- a. "that the national security agencies take immediate steps to strip the UFOs of the special status they have been given and the aura of mystery they have unfortunately acquired;
- b. that the national security agencies institute policies on intelligence, training, and public education designed to prepare the material defenses and the morale of the country to recognize most promptly and to react most effectively to true indications of hostile intent or action."

Besides, the Panel recognized the existence of private and unofficial UFO investigating groups, since "it was believed that such organizations should be watched because of their potentially

great influence on mass thinking if widespread sightings should occur. The apparent irresponsibility and possible use of such groups for subversive purposes should be kept in mind." This document not only confirms that the negative impact of a possible ETI presence on Earth was carefully considered by U.S. authorities in 1953, but also the fact that a definite educational program was recommended and started since then. From a psycho-sociological viewpoint all this is not too different from the recommendations expressed in the 1959 report of the NASA committee on Long-Range Studies (reviewed by Lloyd V. Berkner as Space Science Board head, anthropologist Margaret Mead, et al.). According to the report[15], "since intelligent life might be discovered at any time via the radio telescope research presently under way, and since the consequences of such a discovery are presently unpredictable because of our limited knowledge of behavior under even an approximation of such dramatic circumstances, two research areas can be recommended:

1. Continuing studies to determine emotional and intellectual understanding and attitudes - and successive alterations of them if any - regarding the possibility and consequences of discovering intelligent extraterrestrial life.
2. Historical and empirical studies of the behavior of people and their leaders when confronted with dramatic and unfamiliar events or social pressures."

Such studies, the report continued, should consider reactions to past hoaxes, "flying saucer" episodes and incidents like the 1938 Martian invasion broadcast. As Walter Sullivan underlined in his comment, "they should explore how to release the news of an encounter to the public - or withhold it, if this is deemed advisable[15]." The influence on international relations might be revolutionary, the report concluded, for the discovery of alien beings "might lead to a greater unity of men on Earth, based on the 'oneness' of man or on the age-old assumption that any stranger is threatening."

In this perspective we may remember the controversial "Report from Iron Mountain on the Possibility and Desirability of Peace" edited by L. C. Lewin in 1967. In fact it mentions the purported interest of the U.S. Government in experiments aimed at testing the American people's credibility about the possibility of an invasion from outer space, maybe involving ad hoc man-made "flying saucers" to verify the general public's reactions to the "hostile ETI"

concept[16]. Apart from this or any other possible involvement of intelligence agencies in this kind of research, we must agree that the "hostile ETI" concept could be a good political substitute for war because of its evident possibilities to unite mankind against the danger of a supposed common enemy.

In 1955 General MacArthur, visiting Italy, discussed with Mr. Achille Lauro, the mayor of Naples, about the necessity for the peoples of Earth to unite against a future possible menace from outer space. Exactly 30 years later U.S. President Ronald Reagan expressed the same concept with the Soviet Premier, Mikhail Gorbachev, during their meeting in Iceland[17]. Is this only political utopia or the surfacing of a world-wide unconscious form of cosmic xenophobia due to our age-old anthropocentrism and prejudice? We still tend to think of ourselves or of our own culture as "the center," as the "best of all possible civilizations." But our future may well depend on the speed with which we can discard these prejudices. Surely this could be another reason for SETI scientists to be involved in the educational strategy we proposed: a multi-level model in which roles and tasks are easy to understand. In fact, SETI scientists are the ideal consultants and "catalyzers" of this general educational action to be accomplished through the mass media. Journalists, in any case, will be glad to develop new stimulating ideas and information since this is their normal activity, and it is evident that they will do their best to cooperate.

As far as the political world is concerned, along with the intelligence agencies behind it, they will be glad to see and verify the growing development of a mass conscience impervious to the dangers of the impact of contact in a general context of psycho-social stability. All this means that this long-term educational strategy could be the right answer to whatever may happen. As the heirs of Copernicus, SETI scientists' moral duty is to complete the Copernican Revolution in today's world: that is, in psycho-sociological sense. Surely the future of the human civilization may be conditioned by our preparing the public before releasing the news that ETI exist. It is a definite historical duty for all of us.

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